DIGITAL LITERACY PROJECT REPORT

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Year – 1st Year

Course Code- Digital literacy (CSE0001)

Date – 29th March 2026

INTRODUCTION

Being selected as a Student Digital Ambassador at my college feels like a mix of "finally, I can help" and "wow, this is a huge responsibility."

We're all online 24/7 submitting assignments, Venmo-ing friends for coffee, or doomscrolling through LinkedIn. But honestly? Most of us are just winging it. We don't really stop to think about *how* we're using these platforms or if we're actually leaving a digital trail we'll regret later. That's exactly what this project is meant to tackle.

For my first assignment, I'm building a **Digital Literacy Portfolio**. It's not just a boring academic requirement; it's a toolkit I'll be presenting to faculty and sharing with my batchmates to help us all get our digital lives in order.

Why This Matters

The goal is to bridge the gap between knowing how to use an app and being digitally savvy. These aren't just college skills they're the exact things recruiters look for when we start applying for internships and jobs.

The portfolio is broken down into five practical areas:

- **The Big Picture:** Defining what digital literacy actually looks like in 2026.
- **The Digital Mirror:** Reviewing and polishing our online profiles
- **Tool Deep-Dive:** Exploring platforms that actually make us more productive, not just busier.
- **The Art of the Inbox:** Mastering professional email communication so we stop sounding like we're texting.
- **Cyber-Self Defense:** Learning how to spot threats and stay safe in an increasingly messy online world.

I don't want this to be a theoretical lecture. I want it to be practical, relatable, and above all useful. I'm hoping this project helps all of us turn our digital habits from "autopilot" to "intentional."

TASK 1 - *Create a Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic*

When I sat down to create this visual, I went straight to **Canva**. I didn't want it to look like some dry, academic PDF that people would just scroll past; I wanted it to actually look like something we'd find useful. The design basically maps out our digital lives—from the tools we use like Notion and AI, to the "unspoken rules" of LinkedIn and email etiquette.

The hardest part, honestly? It wasn't the content, thing I found slightly difficult was not adding too much information. At first, it looked a bit crowded, so I had to remove a few points and keep it clean. But that actually helped me make the design more effective and easier to understand.

Balancing the text with enough white space so it's actually readable was a massive learning curve for me. It really made me realize that being "digitally literate" isn't just about using the tools—it's about how we present that information to others in a way that actually sticks. For this task, I used Canva to create my digital literacy awareness infographic. I went with Canva because it's simple to use and made it easy to turn my ideas into something visual without spending too much time on design from scratch.

Task 2: Build your Student Digital Portfolio

For this task, I chose to work on GitHub, LinkedIn, and ResearchGate because each platform plays a different role in building a professional online presence. Together, they give a balanced mix of technical, professional, and academic exposure, which I felt was important at this stage.

GitHub is mainly used to showcase coding projects and technical work. I created my profile README and added basic details like my name, branch, year, and a short line about what I want to learn. It felt like a good starting point to slowly build a portfolio of my work.

LinkedIn is more focused on professional networking, so I updated my education details with my current degree, college, and expected graduation year. It seems like a platform where I can connect with people, explore internships, and stay updated with industry trends.

ResearchGate was something I wasn’t very familiar with before, but I understood that it is useful for sharing research work and connecting with people in academic fields.

Over the next four years, I plan to keep improving these profiles. I want to regularly upload projects on GitHub, stay active and build connections on LinkedIn, and explore ResearchGate more as I get involved in academic work. Overall, this task made me realize that building a digital presence early can really help in the long run.

Task 3: Explore Coding & Collaboration Platforms

For this task, I worked on HackerRank for coding practice and Google Forms for collaboration. I chose HackerRank because I had heard about it before and wanted to try solving some basic problems. I completed a beginner-level challenge, which helped me understand how coding questions are structured and how to think step by step while solving them. It was a bit confusing at first, but once I got the idea, it actually felt interesting and motivating.

For the second part, I created a Google Form with five questions based on digital literacy. I included both multiple choice and a short answer question so that it’s not just about guessing but also thinking. I also checked how the responses are collected in Google Sheets, which was something new for me.

Overall, this task helped me explore tools that I can actually use in my studies. HackerRank can help me improve my coding skills with regular practice and make my problem-solving skills stronger over time. It also gives a clear idea of how programming is applied in real questions, not just theory. On the other hand, Google Forms is very useful for creating quizzes, collecting opinions, and even working on group projects. I feel these tools will be helpful not just for assignments but also for improving my overall academic performance in the coming years.

Task 4: Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

One common situation where poor digital communication can create real problems is when a student sends an email to a professor in a very casual or incomplete way. For example, writing something like “Send deadline pls” or “I need extension” without any proper subject, greeting, or explanation. In such cases, the message can come across as rude or careless, even if that was not the intention. Because of this, the professor might ignore the email or may not take the request seriously, which could result in the student missing an important deadline or opportunity.

I think the main issue here is not understanding how important tone and clarity are in online communication. Since emails don’t show expressions or voice, the way we write matters a lot more. Even small things like starting with a proper greeting, clearly explaining the situation, and ending politely can make a big difference. It shows respect and also makes it easier for the other person to understand the request.

If the same message was written properly, with a clear subject, a short explanation, and a polite tone, the outcome could be completely different. The professor would be more likely to respond positively. This shows that good digital communication is not just about writing, but also about being thoughtful and responsible.

Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness

PART(A) case study describing: what the crime is, how it typically happens (step-by-step), who is usually targeted, and what the consequences are.

Cybercrime Case Study: UPI Payment Fraud

With the rise of UPI payments in India, sending and receiving money has become very easy, especially for students who use it almost daily. However, this convenience has also made it easier for scammers to trick people who are not fully aware of how these systems work.

A common situation happens when a student tries to sell something online, like books or gadgets. A person contacts them pretending to be a genuine buyer and quickly agrees to the price, which builds trust. Then, instead of actually sending money, the scammer sends a “collect request” on a UPI app. At the same time, they may call or message the student and say that accepting the request is required to receive the payment.

Since the student is expecting money, they don’t think much and approve the request by entering their UPI PIN. But instead of receiving money, the amount gets deducted from their account. By the time they realize, the scammer has already disappeared.

This type of fraud mostly targets college students and new users who are not fully aware of how payment requests work. The consequences include financial loss, stress, and sometimes loss of confidence in online systems.

This case shows that basic awareness, like knowing that receiving money never requires entering a PIN, can help avoid such scams.

PART(B) what surprised you most while researching this topic, and one habit you will personally change as a result.

While researching this topic, what honestly surprised me the most was how simple and common these scams actually are. Before this, I always thought cybercrime meant something very technical, like hacking into systems or breaking security codes. But after going through different examples, I realized that many scams don't involve advanced technology at all. They mostly depend on small mistakes, confusion, or lack of awareness from the user's side. Something as simple as clicking on the wrong link or approving a UPI request without reading it properly can lead to losing money within seconds. That was something I hadn't really thought about before.

One habit I will personally change after this is being more careful and not rushing while doing anything online, especially when it comes to payments. Earlier, if I was in a hurry, I would sometimes just approve requests or click on things without paying full attention. Now I understand how risky that can be. I will make sure to always double-check details like the type of request, the name, and what exactly I am approving before entering my PIN or any personal information.

Overall, this topic has made me more aware and slightly more cautious in a good way. It showed me that staying safe online is not difficult, but it does require being alert and thinking for a few extra seconds before taking any action.

Conclusion

Working on this project has honestly changed the way I look at my digital life. Before this, I used most online platforms without thinking too much whether it was sending emails, making payments, or using social media. But while completing each task, I realized that being digitally literate is not just about knowing how to use apps, but about using them in a smart, safe, and responsible way.

One of the biggest things I learned is that small actions matter a lot. Writing a proper email, keeping my online profiles updated, or even double-checking a payment request are simple habits, but they can make a huge difference. I also understood how important it is to build a professional presence early, instead of waiting until the last moment.

This project didn’t just feel like an assignment it felt practical and useful. I feel more confident now when it comes to using digital tools, communicating online, and being careful about safety.

Overall, this experience has made me more aware and a bit more responsible in how I use technology. Going forward, I’ll try to apply these habits in my daily life and also help others around me do the same.

REFERENCE

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github.com

linkedin.com

hackerrank.com

codechef.com

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cybercrime.gov.in

Cyber Crime Helpline 1930 (24x7 phone)